fossil fuel in the deep sea, e.g. off the Brazilian coast or in the rain forests of the Amazon, in the polar ice of Siberia and the Arctic Ocean or in the tar sands of Venezuela or Canada. Also with regard to mineral and agricultural raw materials, the natural limits are losing their horror because unconventional resources are found and new conventional reserves are located, such as rare metals and soil in China, or coal in India, or non-conventional plants for the production of bio-energy in Brazil and in South Africa (sugar cane, soya, palm oil, etc.). This means that the limits of resources are indeed flexible ones and that it is possible, as green protagonists promise, that 'the limits grow' and therefore the 'limits of growth', which the Club of Rome first mentioned in 1972, can be neglected.

This flexibility is welcomed as a chance for development by many governments and social movements everywhere in the world. BRICS governments now can opt for the application of a neo-extractivist strategy. It is different from the traditional, colonial and imperialist extractivism, because the extracted mineral ores or agricultural products or riches from the rain forests are not simply robbed by the metropolises of the imperialist world system. Instead, the whole chain of commodification and monetisation of natural resources in the world market remains under the control of strong and mostly left governments. Therefore the neo-extractivist strategies also have been called 'development extractivism' (Bolivian Vice-President Linera). This strategy can be successful so long as the resources do not come to an end, so long as the terms of trade are favourable for primary goods, and so long as the governments concerned are not corrupt and do not play to the tune of transnational corporations. But although natural limits are flexible, they are not nonexistent. On the contrary, they matter and therefore a development extractivist strategy from the very beginning must aim at an alternative, a non-extractivist development model. Even a middle-range development extractivism strategy can be trapped in the economic grinder of the 'resource curse', in the dilemma of the 'Dutch disease', and in the contradictions between internal and external terms of trade.

Moreover, the global 'sinks' (storage) for emissions react less flexibly than the limits on resource availability, given the demand for energy, mineral and agricultural resources. The planetary boundaries with regard to many resources have already been surpassed. It is possible to disregard them, but flouting these natural limits surely will provoke sanctions, perhaps with a time lag, perhaps immediately. Therefore natural limits at the end of the fossil era indeed matter everywhere and for everybody on Earth. They require common action in a world which is – as already shown – divided into strong, but not hegemonic, nation-states which are using methods of geo-engineering (in information politics as well